

Psalms 80

Turn Us Again, O God

Turn us again, O God of hosts, and cause thy face to shine
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 Give ear, O Shepherd of Israel, thou that leadest Joseph like a flock; thou that dwellest between the cherubims, shine forth.
- 2 Before Ephraim and Benjamin and Manasseh stir up thy strength, and come and save us.
- 3 Turn us again, O God, and cause thy face to shine; and we shall be saved.
- 4 O LORD God of hosts, how long wilt thou be angry against the prayer of thy people?
- 5 Thou feedest them with the bread of tears; and givest them tears to drink in great measure.
- 6 Thou makest us a strife unto our neighbours: and our enemies laugh among themselves.
- 7 Turn us again, O God of hosts, and cause thy face to shine; and we shall be saved.
- 8 Thou hast brought a vine out of Egypt: thou hast cast out the heathen, and planted it.
- 9 Thou preparedst room before it, and didst cause it to take deep root, and it filled the land.
- 10 The hills were covered with the shadow of it, and the boughs thereof were like the goodly cedars.
- 11 She sent out her boughs unto the sea, and her branches unto the river.
- 12 Why hast thou then broken down her hedges, so that all they which pass by the way do pluck her?
- 13 The boar out of the wood doth waste it, and the wild beast of the field doth devour it.
- 14 Return, we beseech thee, O God of hosts: look down from heaven, and behold, and visit this vine;
- 15 And the vineyard which thy right hand hath planted, and the branch that thou madest strong for thyself.
- 16 It is burned with fire, it is cut down: they perish at the rebuke of thy countenance.
- 17 Let thy hand be upon the man of thy right hand, upon the son of man whom thou madest strong for thyself.
- 18 So will not we go back from thee: quicken us, and we will call upon thy name.
- 19 Turn us again, O LORD God of hosts, cause thy face to shine; and we shall be saved.

2 · CONTEXT

Asaph prays for the northern tribes—Joseph, Ephraim, Benjamin, Manasseh named specifically—using the extended image of Israel as a vine that God Himself brought out of Egypt, planted, and once caused to flourish across the land, but which now lies broken down and ravaged. The repeated refrain, 'turn us again... cause your face to shine... we shall be saved,' structures the whole psalm around a single request: not merely relief from the immediate crisis, but restored relationship with God as the actual solution.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

The prayer opens by addressing God as Shepherd of Israel, the one who leads Joseph like a flock and dwells enthroned between the cherubim, asking Him to shine forth and save the northern tribes specifically. The refrain appears for the first time: turn us again, cause your face to shine, and we shall be saved.

Verse 4-7

The complaint intensifies: how long will God's anger smolder against His own people's prayer? They have been fed with the bread of tears, given tears to drink in full measure, made a source of strife among neighbors and mockery among enemies. The refrain repeats, now addressed to the 'God of hosts.'

Verse 8-13

The extended vine metaphor unfolds: God brought this vine out of Egypt, cleared the ground, and it took deep root and filled the land, its shade covering the hills, its branches reaching to the sea and the river—a picture of Israel's earlier flourishing under God's care. Then comes the devastating question: why have you broken down its hedges, so that anyone passing by plucks its fruit, a wild boar ravages it, and every beast of the field feeds on it?

Verse 14-16

The plea intensifies into direct address: return, God of hosts, look down from heaven, behold and visit this vine—the very branch you made strong for yourself—now burned and cut down, perishing at the rebuke of your countenance.

Verse 17-19

The prayer's resolution names 'the man of your right hand,' a coming figure through whom restoration will come; the people commit that they will not turn back from God if He revives them. The refrain closes the psalm a final time, now fullest: turn us again, Lord God of hosts, cause your face to shine, and we shall be saved.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

The deepest crisis this psalm names is not the vine's outward devastation but the broken relationship behind it—God's face turned away. The repeated refrain insists that restoration of fellowship with God, not merely improved circumstances, is the actual remedy being sought; salvation is defined here as God's face shining again, not simply as disaster reversed.

Application for life today.

When your own life or community feels like the ravaged vine of this psalm—flourishing once, now broken down—resist settling for circumstantial fixes and pray specifically for restored nearness to God, as the refrain models. Notice how the psalmist names Israel's earlier flourishing honestly (vv. 8–11) rather than downplaying what has been lost; grief over a genuine loss of blessing is appropriate here. Let the psalm's refrain become your own prayer in a hard season: not just 'fix this,' but 'turn us again, and let your face shine.'

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where in your life does the image of a once-flourishing vine now broken down (vv. 8–13) resonate with a real loss you are grieving?

2. How does the refrain's request—God's face shining, not just circumstances improving—reshape what you are actually asking for in prayer right now?

3. Who is 'the man of your right hand' (v. 17) ultimately fulfilled in, and how does that shape your hope for restoration?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).